

MANDAR DEODHAR

MORAL VICTORY?
Uddhav Thackeray

THE THACKERAY CAMP CLAIMS THAT THE SC RULING WILL BOOST SYMPATHY FOR THEM AMONG VOTERS DUE TO THE PERCEPTION THAT THEY HAVE BEEN WRONGED

A rainbow coalition of three radically diverse parties such as the Shiv Sena, NCP and the Congress, the MVA was seen as a convenient arrangement to keep the BJP out of power. This made the MVA government's demise more of a tactical and expedient necessity for the saffron party. And while the Thackeray faction may have sympathy on its side for the moment, the challenge, says a legislator from the camp, lies in maintaining this sentiment as "much water would have flown down the bridge by the time the elections take place." The elections to local bodies, including the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation, are likely to take place after October and seen as the warm-up for the Lok Sabha polls due early next year.

A senior Congress leader and former minister also points to how the Shiv Sena and MVA leaderships have taken a series of missteps. "Thackeray should have faced a trust vote and spoken in the House before putting in his papers like Atal Bihari Vajpayee did in 1996. This would have also made for good optics. Thackeray backed off perhaps because he felt he would have been insulted by the rebels... it also showed that he had no idea about how parliamentary democracy functions," he explains. More crucially, in February 2021, Nana Patole, who was appointed the president of the Maharashtra Congress, stepped down as the assembly speaker, reportedly without consulting his MVA colleagues. Koshyari, the then-governor, sat on the MVA government's request to call for elections to the post. Rahul Narwekar of the BJP was elected as the speaker only after the new regime took charge.

Now, the SC has asked Narwekar to decide on the disqualification petitions filed by the rival camps against their legislators "within a reasonable period." Of the 56 Shiv Sena MLAs, disqualification petitions have been filed against 54, except Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) leader Aaditya Thackeray and Latke. In the records of the legislature, the Shiv Sena legislature party is considered as one unit. The court said the speaker would "prima facie determine who the political party is for the purpose of adjudicating disqualification petitions". In a shot in the arm for the Thackeray faction, the SC ruled that the political party, and not the legislature party, appoints the whip and the leader of the party in the House. Narwekar's decision to recognise Shinde loyalist and Mahad MLA Bharat Gogawale as the Shiv Sena's chief whip was also termed "illegal" as it was based solely on the resolution of a faction of the legislature party. It said the speaker shall recognise the whip and the group leader authorised by the Shiv Sena political party and this should be done after referring to the party constitution, after conducting an enquiry and in keeping with the principles in the SC judgment.

Senior editor and political analyst Sandeep Pradhan says Maharashtra could now witness a battle between two competing narratives. One by the Thackeray side, which claims that the BJP had reneged on its word to share the CM's position with the Shiv Sena, forcing him to join hands with the Congress and the NCP, and then, the BJP misused the machinery, including the central probe agencies, to topple his regime. The counter-narrative by Shinde and the BJP is that Thackeray had betrayed the ideology of Hindutva to ally with "secular" parties like the Congress and the NCP for power. "The side that can present its side more convincingly to the masses will gain," says Pradhan, adding that the SC's decision could also widen the fissures between the BJP and Shinde. "The verdict has come as a morale booster for Shinde and his men. Hence, Shinde may not tolerate any attempts by the BJP state leadership to corner him or to strike a deal with the NCP. On the other hand, it must also be noted that the speaker, whose role in the deadlock is crucial, is a BJP man," he avers. Meanwhile, the election results in Karnataka have thrown another curve ball. MVA constituents believe the BJP's defeat in Karnataka has boosted their chances in Maharashtra were they to contest polls. Districts like Kolhapur, Solapur, Sangli and Latur share their borders with Karnataka. The Lingayats also account for significant numbers in parts of western Maharashtra, Vidarbha and Marathwada. The wicket seems to have turned weak for Shinde and the BJP. ■